

BSH (Bantuan Sara Hidup) & STR (Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah) ELIGIBILITY AND APPLICATION GUIDE

1. Overview and Introduction This document serves as a comprehensive guide regarding the Bantuan Sara Hidup (BSH) financial assistance program, detailing its eligibility criteria, application process, and its evolutionary transition into the current Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah (STR) program as of 2026.

The Malaysian Government has, over the last two decades, developed a substantive social safety net comprising non-contributory social assistance programs. The primary focus of these initiatives is to address chronic poverty, promote equal opportunities, and protect vulnerable low-income families from sudden economic shocks and the rising cost of living. Unlike health and education services where the impacts on poverty are observed over a long-term period, direct cash transfers like BSH and STR offer immediate financial support to households in need.

While users frequently search for "BSH eligibility" due to the historical popularity of the Bantuan Sara Hidup name, it is vital to understand that the Malaysian government frequently rebrands and restructures its cash transfer programs. BSH, which was prominently active around 2019 and 2020, replaced the earlier Bantuan Rakyat 1Malaysia (BR1M). Subsequently, the program evolved into Bantuan Prihatin Nasional (BPN) during the pandemic, Bantuan Prihatin Rakyat (BPR), Bantuan Keluarga Malaysia (BKM), and presently operates under the name Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah (STR) for the 2024 to 2026 financial years. This document covers the historical context of BSH to fulfill legacy inquiries while providing the exact, up-to-date eligibility and application frameworks for the STR 2026 program.

2. Historical Context: The Bantuan Sara Hidup (BSH) Framework Understanding the original BSH framework is essential for grasping how the government classifies the B40 (Bottom 40%) income group. Officially implemented in 2019 under the administration of the Inland Revenue Board of Malaysia (Lembaga Hasil Dalam Negeri Malaysia - LHDNM), BSH was designed as a targeted cash transfer.

The core eligibility for the historical BSH program was strictly tied to household income. Families earning below RM4,000 a month were the primary beneficiaries. The 2019 BSH model introduced a tiered system based on specific income brackets:

- Households earning RM2,000 and below per month received the highest base financial aid.
- Households earning between RM2,001 and RM3,000 received a moderate base financial aid.
- Households earning between RM3,001 and RM4,000 received a lower base financial aid.

A significant innovation of the BSH program was the introduction of child dependents' benefits. In addition to the base household payout, families received an extra RM120 per child aged 18 and below, capped at a maximum of four children. Disabled children (OKU) had no age limit applied to this benefit. This made BSH highly beneficial for larger families with lower incomes.

However, the legacy BSH system faced challenges, particularly concerning the self-employed and informal sector workers. Because eligibility verification relied heavily on formal LHDNM tax data and formal employment records (like EPF or SOCSO), vulnerable gig economy workers, street vendors, and freelancers who did not register their businesses or file formal tax returns were sometimes inadvertently excluded. Addressing these gaps became the foundation for the modernized Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah (STR) system.

3. Current Framework: Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah (STR) 2026 For the year 2026, the active cash assistance program is the Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah (STR). STR is a direct continuation and enhancement of the BSH philosophy, aimed at low and middle-income groups who are genuinely qualified and in need of assistance to face the cost of living challenges. The government's subsidy rationalization efforts have allowed for increased cash handouts through STR 2026, ensuring that low-income households continue to receive appropriate financial aid.

The STR 2026 program categorizes beneficiaries into three main groups: Households (Isi Rumah), Senior Citizens Without Partners (Warga Emas Tiada Pasangan), and Singles (Bujang). The criteria have been refined to ensure broader and more accurate coverage, utilizing multi-agency database cross-checking to minimize exclusion errors.

4. Comprehensive Eligibility Criteria for STR 2026 To qualify for STR 2026, applicants must be Malaysian citizens residing and working in Malaysia (where applicable). The specific eligibility conditions are strictly divided by category.

Category A: Households (Isi Rumah) To apply under the household category, the applicant must be a male or female serving as the head of the family. The total gross monthly household income must be RM5,000 and below. The applicant's marital status must be Married, or they must be a Single Parent, Widow, Widower, or Divorced individual who possesses children that meet the specific dependency conditions.

- **Spousal Requirements:** The spouse of the applicant must be a Malaysian citizen holding a MyKad, or possess a Malaysian identification document such as MyPR (Permanent Resident) or MyKAS (Temporary Resident). Non-citizens without MyPR or MyKAS can also be registered as spouses, provided the primary applicant is a Malaysian citizen.

- **Child Dependency Requirements:** The dependents must be biological children (including illegitimate children recognized legally) or legally adopted children registered with the National Registration Department (Jabatan Pendaftaran Negara - JPN). The child must be a Malaysian citizen holding a MyKad or MyKid. Furthermore, the child must not be employed or possess any source of income. The age limit for a dependent child is 18 years old and below. However, if the child is 19 years old and above, they are still eligible to be claimed as a dependent if they are studying full-time at a Public Higher Education Institution (IPTA) or a Private Higher Education Institution (IPTS).

Category B: Senior Citizens Without Partners (Warga Emas Tiada Pasangan) This category caters to the elderly population who do not have a spouse or eligible dependents to rely upon.

- **Marital Status:** The applicant must be Single, or a Single Parent, Widow, Widower, or Divorced individual who does not have any children that meet the dependency conditions outlined in the household category.
- **Age Requirement:** The applicant must be 60 years of age and above.
- **Income Requirement:** The total gross monthly income of the senior citizen must be RM5,000 and below.

Category C: Singles (Bujang) This category provides financial relief to young and middle-aged unmarried individuals who are in the lower income brackets.

- **Marital Status:** The applicant must be Single, or a Single Parent, Widow, Widower, or Divorced individual without any eligible dependent children.
- **Age Requirement:** The standard age requirement is between 21 and 59 years old. However, for Singles who are registered as Persons with Disabilities (Orang Kurang Upaya - OKU), the age limit is lowered, encompassing individuals from 19 to 59 years old.
- **Educational Status:** The applicant must not be a full-time student at an IPTA or IPTS. Individuals aged 21 and above (or OKU aged 19 and above) who are still studying full-time are not allowed to apply as a Single individual; instead, they must be registered as a dependent under their parents' or guardians' Household application.
- **Income Requirement:** The total gross monthly income of the single applicant must be RM2,500 and below.

5. Integration with Sumbangan Asas Rahmah (SARA) 2026 An integral part of the modern STR system is its integration with the Sumbangan Asas Rahmah (SARA)

program. SARA is an additional targeted subsidy designed to provide monthly allowances for basic necessities.

Qualification for SARA is determined automatically based on the approved STR 2026 data. It specifically targets the Hardcore Poor and Poor groups listed in the eKasih database managed by the Implementation Coordination Unit, Prime Minister's Department (ICU, JPM). However, for 2026, the SARA benefits have been expanded to include all STR 2026 recipients across the Household, Single, and Senior Citizen categories.

Unlike the direct cash deposits of the standard STR, SARA utilizes a cashless mechanism. Eligible recipients can use their Malaysian Identification Card (MyKad) as a debit tool to purchase selected basic daily necessities at registered supermarkets and grocery stores nationwide. For instance, Household and Senior Citizen recipients receive monthly SARA credits starting from January 2026, while Single category recipients receive their credits on a slightly staggered schedule.

Additionally, the government occasionally announces universal one-off aids under the SARA umbrella, such as the RM100 SARA aid, which features straightforward, universal eligibility for all Malaysian citizens aged 18 and above with a valid MyKad, regardless of income requirements. It is important to distinguish between targeted monthly SARA (tied to STR) and these universal one-off SARA distributions.

6. Application and Registration Process The application process for STR 2026 has been modernized to be as accessible as possible. The government allows applications to be made throughout the year, typically starting from October of the preceding year (e.g., October 2025 for STR 2026).

It is a mandatory requirement that any STR application that has not been updated for three consecutive years must be updated to ensure the disbursement of funds is accurate and reaches the intended recipient.

- **Online Application:** The most efficient method to apply or update information is online via the official STR portal (bantuan.tunai.hasil.gov.my). Applicants can log in using their registered credentials or via the MyDigital ID integration. The online portal allows users to submit new applications (Permohonan Baharu), update basic profiles, and modify beneficiary information (Kemas Kini Maklumat Asas).
- **Manual Application:** For those residing in rural areas without reliable internet access, or for elderly citizens who lack digital literacy, manual paper form submissions are fully supported. Applicants can visit any nearby Inland Revenue Board of Malaysia (LHDNM) office to fill out and submit the physical application forms.

- **Beneficiary Updates (Maklumat Waris):** A critical step in the registration process is the updating of beneficiary details. If an STR recipient passes away, the registered beneficiary (Waris) is entitled to claim the remaining STR balance and the Khairat Kematian (Death Benefit or SKK). The portal allows users to specify and update the details of their next of kin to facilitate seamless claims at Bank Simpanan Nasional (BSN) branches.

7. Verification and Cross-Checking Mechanism To maintain the integrity of the STR program and ensure that funds go only to the truly deserving, LHDNM employs a rigorous data verification process. Approval is not guaranteed upon submission; every application undergoes a thorough review.

LHDNM cross-references applicant data with databases from over 10 different government agencies. These include:

- The National Registration Department (JPN) to verify citizenship, age, and marital status.
- The Employees Provident Fund (EPF/KWSP) and the Retirement Fund Incorporated (KWAP) to assess income levels and pension statuses.
- The Companies Commission of Malaysia (SSM) to detect undeclared business ownership.
- The Accountant General's Department and various other agencies to ensure there is no duplication of benefits and that income declarations are entirely accurate. This comprehensive cross-checking mitigates instances of fraudulent claims and prevents high-income individuals from unlawfully receiving B40 assistance.

8. Payment Phases and Disbursement Methods The disbursement of STR funds is structurally divided into multiple phases throughout the year (typically Phase 1, Phase 2, Phase 3, and Phase 4) to ensure a steady stream of financial support for low-income families.

For the 2026 cycle, Phase 1 payments begin in late January, while Phase 2 payments commence in March. The exact dates are staggered depending on the recipient's bank and category.

There are two primary methods of payment:

- **Direct Bank Crediting:** The standard and preferred method is direct electronic transfer. Funds are credited straight into the active personal bank account of the successful applicant or their registered spouse.
- **Cash Over Counter (Penunaian di Cawangan):** For recipients who do not possess a bank account, or whose bank accounts have gone dormant or failed during the

crediting process, the government partners with Bank Simpanan Nasional (BSN). These recipients receive a voucher or an approval notification, which they must present alongside their physical MyKad at any BSN branch to cash out their allocated funds.

9. The Appeal Process (Rayuan) It is common for some applications to be initially rejected (marked as "TIDAK LULUS" or "TIDAK LAYAK"). Common reasons for rejection include cross-agency data indicating that the applicant's income exceeds the permissible threshold, the applicant being registered as an active SSM business owner without declaring appropriate income, or the applicant being identified as a full-time student despite applying under the Single category.

The government recognizes that automated data can sometimes be outdated. Therefore, an extensive appeal (Rayuan) period is provided. For example, for STR 2026 Phase 1 rejections, the appeal window typically opens from mid-January to mid-February.

Applicants can submit their appeals either through the online STR portal or physically at LHDNM offices. During the appeal, applicants must provide supporting documents to challenge the rejection reason. For instance, if an application was rejected due to SSM registration but the business is no longer operational, the applicant must provide official termination documents from SSM. If the income data was incorrectly reported as too high, the applicant should provide recent payslips, termination letters from employers, or updated EPF statements proving their current lowered income status. Once the appeal is submitted, LHDNM will conduct a manual re-verification process before issuing a final decision in the subsequent payment phases.

10. Security and Scam Awareness With the massive scale of the STR and SARA financial distributions, recipients frequently become targets for cybercriminals and scammers.

It is a strict government policy that the Ministry of Finance (MOF) and LHDNM will never request personal information, banking details, or passwords through SMS, WhatsApp, or phone calls. Scammers often send fake text messages containing malicious links, claiming that the user must click the link to claim their STR funds.

Users are strictly advised to only verify their application status and make updates via the official portal at bantuan.tunai.hasil.gov.my. No banking Transaction Authorisation Code (TAC) or Personal Identification Number (PIN) is ever required by the government to deposit STR funds into a recipient's account.

11. Conclusion The evolution from Bantuan Sara Hidup (BSH) to the Sumbangan Tunai Rahmah (STR) represents the Malaysian government's ongoing commitment to refining its welfare distribution mechanisms. By combining direct cash transfers with targeted

basic necessity subsidies like SARA, and implementing strict cross-agency verification alongside a fair appeal process, the system aims to provide a robust, inclusive, and highly accurate safety net for the nation's most economically vulnerable citizens.